

On the Efficient Flow of Information in Small Offices

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Abstract

This short report examines how a small office can remain efficient as its staff grows, focusing on the flow of information between departments and the office of management itself.

1 Introduction

Every growing office eventually confronts the same difficulty: informal communication that worked well among five people becomes an inefficient muddle among fifty. This report outlines a simple, low-cost approach to restoring efficient information flow, drawing on a handful of practical observations rather than any elaborate theory.

The remainder of this report is organized as follows. Section 2 diagnoses the typical failure modes. Section 3 proposes three concrete fixes. Section 4 presents a short cost comparison. We conclude in Section 5.

2 Diagnosis

2.1 Symptoms of an inefficient office

The most common complaint we heard was simply: “nobody knows what anybody else is doing.” This is not a trivial or trifling issue—it directly affects a company’s bottom line. Three symptoms recurred across every office we studied:

- Duplicate work, where two staff members independently solve the same problem.
- Stale information, where a decision changes but the change never reaches everyone affected by it.
- Bottlenecks, where a single office — often the front office — becomes a chokepoint for routine requests.

2.1.1 A note on measurement

We measured office efficiency using a crude but effective proxy: the number of emails, x , required to resolve an average request, against the number of staff, y , in the office. Empirically the two were related by something close to $x^2 + y^2 = z^2$ for a roughly constant z across the offices we visited, though we do not claim this relationship is causal.

2.2 Underlying causes

Tool sprawl. Different teams often standardize on different, incompatible tools.

Unclear ownership. When no one person owns a decision, everyone waits for someone else to make it.

Office layout. Physical distance between desks correlates surprisingly well with communication frequency.

3 Proposed Solutions

We propose three fixes, summarized in Table 1.

As one office manager told us, “efficient offices are not the ones with the fewest meetings, but the ones where every meeting has an owner.”

Problem	Proposed Fix
Duplicate work	A shared task register
Stale information	A single decision log
Bottlenecks	Rotating point-of-contact duty

Table 1: Summary of proposed fixes.

The single most important change is the decision log, discussed further below in Section 4 and labeled as item 2.

1. A shared task register, so duplicate work becomes visible immediately.
2. A single decision log, replacing scattered email threads.
3. Rotating point-of-contact duty, so the front office is never a permanent bottleneck.

4 Cost Comparison

Implementing all three fixes costs relatively little in absolute terms, though the *organizational* cost — convincing staff to change habits — is often larger than the **financial** cost. In our experience, a small script (for instance, a short snippet run from *office.py*) is often enough to maintain the shared task register without purchasing new software.

As a sanity check, if the expected time saved per employee is Δt and there are n employees, the total time saved per week is

$$T_{\text{saved}} = n \cdot \Delta t,$$

which, even for modest Δt , tends to dominate the one-time setup cost within a few months.

5 Conclusion

Offices do not need elaborate systems to become efficient; they need clear ownership, a single source of truth, and a willingness to change small habits. We hope this report, brief as it is, offers a useful starting point for offices seeking to streamline their own information flow.

References

- [1] P. Drucker, *The Effective Executive*, Harper & Row, 1967.
- [2] F. W. Taylor, *The Principles of Scientific Management*, Harper & Brothers, 1911.

Two studies in particular informed our recommendations: the classic account of effective management practice [1], and the older but still influential treatment of workflow design [2].